

snow on their tongues. When we got back to the village, we found the parents waiting for us outside the pack house. Finlay must have mindlinked them. They all thanked me for entertaining their pups in the morning. I told them it was my pleasure.

“You looked like a pup,” Finlay remarked when we were alone, heading for the meeting room.

“I feel like one in the snow. That’s why I like to entertain pups on snow days like this. It gives me a good excuse to act like one.”

“It’s not often I see you so relaxed, Red. I think the snow does you good. But maybe put a hat on,” he told me and brushed snow from my head.

“Hey, watch the hair,” I said. More out of habit than because I was upset. He just smiled. As we walked into the meeting room, the others were already there.

“You found her,” Meadow said with a smile.

“I did,” Finlay agreed.

“You could have just mindlinked me, you know,” I told them as I took my seat after taking off my jacket.

“And miss the opportunity to see you tumble around the snow with the pups? I don’t think so, Red.” We all settled down and everyone turned their attention to Finlay, we knew he had something important to tell us.

“I received a call from Alpha Jackson of the Rolling Hills pack this morning,” he told us. We all nodded. “They are not an ally. What do you know about them?” he asked.

“They are a mid-tier pack,” Martin said.

“We don’t share any allies with them, so we haven’t interacted with them,” Sam added.

“I know my old pack did some trade with them. But I don’t know any details,” Meadow told us.

“They were too low rank for my old pack to consider a friendship with them. I have heard their old Alpha was a strong leader and the pack had a higher rank when he was Alpha. I think the current Alpha is his nephew or something like that. As I heard from my dad, he isn’t as strong of an Alpha as the former and they had dropped in rank because of it. I think they lost some allies as well,” I said. Finlay nodded. We all wanted to know why the Alpha had reached out to Finlay, but no one asked. If Finlay wanted us to know, he would tell us.

“Alpha Jackson made me an offer. He said he knew that with us being unranked, we were vulnerable. He said he had a stable pack with a good reputation and he offered us to join them,” Finlay informed us. We all looked at him for a moment, trying to take in the information.

“They want us to join them?” Martin asked.

“As in; we merge with them and their Alpha becomes our Alpha?” Sam asked. I felt both myself and my wolf object to the thought.

“Yes,” Finlay said. “I know it feels strange to consider, but if it will keep the pack safe, we should at least discuss it.” I looked at Meadow and I knew she was thinking the same thing I was.

“This doesn't feel right,” she said.

“I agree. Something is missing. Did they ask for something in return for their generosity?” I asked. Finlay gave us a grin that wasn't happy.

“Yes, your instincts are correct. If we accept their offer, they expect us to hand over all pack assets, including the land, to them.”

“Hell no!” Martin called out.

“I'm with him,” I told Finlay.

“I don't like this at all,” Sam said.

“I'm with the rest of you,” Meadow told us.

“I'm happy I and the pack have your loyalty. But, as I said, we need to talk about it before we refuse it,” Finlay insisted.

“Fine. Let's talk about why we think they really extended their offer. None of us thinks it's out of kindness, right?” I said.

“Right. They would have offered to take us in before we settled down if they just wanted to help,” Martin agreed.

“They want, or need, our land,” Sam said.

“Do we know where they are located?” I asked.

“Not specifically, as we aren't allies. But we know the general area,” Finlay told me.

“Let's look it up on a satellite map, see if there is anything we can deduce from it,” I suggested. Martin connected his laptop to the big screen on the wall and searched for the area Finlay gave him.

“Oh,” Meadow said as she saw it.

“That explains it,” Sam agreed. The map showed an area of mostly grass plains with rocky terrain popping up like islands. The few trees in the area stood spread out. As we moved over the map, we found some villages and some smaller cities, but nowhere did we see any forests or land that looked unoccupied by humans.

“It has to be difficult living there as a wolf,” Finlay remarked.

“They have to be on the constant lookout for humans,” Meadow said, there was a lot of compassion in her voice.

“They are looking for a way to get out of the situation,” I concluded.

“Then we offer to take them in, under our current Alpha and our pack,” Martin suggested. Both Finlay and I shook our heads.

"It won't work. We won't inherit their rank just because we take in their members. The only way to get the protection of their rank is for us to join them," Finlay explained.

"That sucks," Sam said.

"But won't it be a deterrent?" Martin asked.

"How do you mean?" Finlay wanted to know.

"If we take their pack into ours. Won't other packs know it and see it as us increasing in strength? Which would make them less likely to want to fight us," Martin explained.

"That is a good point," Finlay told him.

"But do we want these wolves in our pack?" I asked. Everyone looked at me. "I'm not saying we shouldn't be willing to help others. But I don't think we have explored their motives deep enough. Yes, we know they need new land. But why get it through merging with another pack?"

"Because they are a decent pack and don't want to attack us?" Meadow suggested.

"Sure. But why do they need another pack's land at all? They are a mid tier pack. According to them, they are a stable pack. They should have the finances to buy new land. If their pack is living on land like that, why don't they pool their resources, sell the land and get new land? When you left your old pack, you had no notice, no time to plan, and you managed, as a new pack, to buy this land. Heck, we have managed to save up so we can buy a couple of more acres in

spring. How long have they lived on that land? How many years have they had to save up to move to a better place?" I asked. There was silence around the table.

"You suspect there is trouble in their pack?" Finlay asked.

"I don't know. I just know that there is a reason why they are still on that piece of land. Until I know what that reason is, I'm not comfortable letting them into our pack. And I will vote no on us joining them. My wolf won't accept a new Alpha," I told him. He chuckled.

"I should have expected as much," he said. "What about the rest of you?"

"A definite no on us joining them. We have a good pack, a strong pack in so many ways. I'm not willing to risk us going back into a pack which doesn't have the right values. I'm open to letting them join us, but I agree with Amie, we need more information," Martin said.

"I agree. No to join them. Maybe to them joining us," Sam agreed. Meadow nodded.

"Maybe we can arrange a meeting and get to know them?" she suggested.

"That is a good idea," Finlay said. "I will call Alpha Jackson and turn his offer down but suggest we find another solution." Everyone agreed.

"Do you want to join me for a beer?" Finlay asked, as everyone got ready to leave.

“Sure,” I said. I got the feeling he had something he wanted to talk about. “How about we get some dinner to go from the pack kitchen?” I suggested.

“Great idea, I heard we are having pizza today.”

“Pizza and beer, that’s a good combo,” I told him. We got our pizza from the kitchen and headed over to Finlay’s house.

“Take a seat on the couch,” he told me as he put his pizza box on the coffee table. As I got comfortable, he lit the big fireplace and got us beer. From the windows of either side of the fireplace you could see his snow-covered garden and beyond that the brook. It was cosy sitting on the sofa with him, eating pizza and enjoying the fire and the view.

“What do you think will happen when I call the Rolling Hills Alpha?” Finlay asked as I had almost finished my pizza. I put down the slice I was eating and took a moment to think about the question.

“It depends on what kind of Alpha he is. If his intentions with the offer are good, he will most likely understand and be open to an alliance. If he had an ulterior motive, he wouldn’t be happy,” I answered. Finlay nodded. He had a hard look on his face which didn’t suit him. I liked the playful and relaxed look he had most of the time. Even when it was a mask. I could read him well enough that I didn’t need his expression to show me what mood he was in. Irritatingly enough, he was just as good at reading me as I was at reading him.

“Do you think he will try to force the issue?”

“Attack? Maybe, if he is desperate enough. I’m guessing they are uncertain of how strong we are, or that they are weaker than they look. Otherwise, they would have gone for that option from the start. The offer is too risky. They have to know that we won’t just accept it,” I thought out loud. “Or maybe it’s just me being a pessimist and they are really doing it out of the kindness of their heart. You know I like to prepare for the worst. I’m not really a happy, happy, fluffy bunnies and unicorns that farts rainbows kind of a person,” I told him. He burst out laughing and it made me smile. At least I could brighten his mood a little.

“I needed that, thanks,” he said, still chuckling. Then he sighed and turned serious. “I think you are right to be on your guard. Something felt off with the call I had with him. He was too friendly, something with him rubbed my wolf the wrong way,” he said.

“Trust your instinct, it’s a good one. And I know you worry about the pack and about the threat we face because we aren’t ranked. But we are a strong pack, and everyone is willing to take that risk because they believe in this pack and in you as its Alpha. None of us would be here if we didn’t,” I told him.

“Thank you. I think I need to be reminded of that sometimes,” he said. He put his feet on the coffee table. I was about to object when I remembered we were in his house. He leaned back into the couch and looked out the window. It had started snowing again.

“I will remind you when I think you need to hear it. I just don’t want it to go to your head,” I told him and leaned back as well. I didn’t put my feet on the table though. I knew my mother’s spirit would take physical form and smack me in the head if I even tried. Finlay chuckled softly. We sat on the couch, watching the

snow, drinking beer and enjoying the peace and quiet. "I should head back home," I said a couple of hours later. We had time to talk about less gloomy matters and play cards.

"It's really coming down. I have a spare bedroom," he offered. I laughed and gave him a friendly shove.

"I think I will be okay walking ten feet," I said as I headed to the hallway to get my jacket.

"Fine. Just be careful."

"I will. Thank you Finlay for a nice evening. It was fun," I told him.

"Thank you for keeping me company and taking my mind off the call with the Alpha tomorrow."

"No worries. If your mind gets out of control, just mindlink me. I have an astonishing pile of useless facts stored in my head that I am more than happy to recite to you if needed."

"I will keep that in mind," he said as he held open the door. The snow was really coming down, but the few feet between Finlay's and the pack house was still easy to walk. As I reached the front door I felt myself being watched and turned around. I could barely see Finlay's silhouette in the doorway of his house.

"Are you seriously watching me walk ten feet?" I mindlinked him to ask.

"You can't be too careful. Sleep tight, Red," he linked back.

'You too, Alpha. See you tomorrow.'

## Chapter 17



### Finlay

Isighed as I sat down at my desk. I knew I usually joked that I hated being Alpha. It wasn't true. Most days I liked it, it came naturally to me. But there were aspects of it I didn't like. Like paperwork. It was an endless tide of paperwork involved in running the pack. There was the paperwork for the pack and its finances, there was the paperwork the humans demanded we keep, and then there was the paperwork for the council. Since Amie had joined the pack, she had been a great help with it. She knew how much I hated it and how my mood took a turn for the worse when I had to endure it for a long period. So she decided to rescue both me and the pack and give me a hand. Now she always joined me during my paperwork sessions. The work seemed to go by much faster and just having someone to grumble to, made it easier to deal with. And then there was the part of being Alpha that I was heading into. I was about to call Alpha Jackson and tell him we were turning his offer down. It was the right decision; it had been my instinct when he had called me to extend the offer. But I wanted to hear the opinion of my top tiers. To my relief, they had all agreed with me. Amie had taken the last doubt from me during our conversation. I knew I was leaning on her. During the months Amie had been in the pack the thing between us had grown

stronger. We didn't speak about it but I knew she felt it too. I had no idea what it was. I knew it wasn't a mate bond, I wasn't delusional. But it was something. Whatever it was, I enjoyed her company. She always made me feel better and less stressed. Just spending an evening talking and playing cards did wonders. I knew that sooner or later we would need to talk about it. I also had a feeling I wouldn't like her take on it. So, I pushed it into the future. The thoughts about Amie called forth the memory of her playing with the pups in the snow yesterday. It was no big mystery why the pack loved her. She was generous and caring, she was protective of the ones she cared about and she was smart. And yesterday I had learnt the gorgeous wolf had a pup living inside her that was called forth by the snow. To watch her play tag with the pups had been the highlight of my day. I had watched them for a while before making my presence known. I tucked away the memory to use on days when I needed a pick up. I sighed. I was postponing the inevitable. I ran my hand through my hair and picked up the phone.

"Jakson Hill," the other Alpha answered.

"Alpha Jackson, this is Alpha Finlay," I told him.

"Ah, Finlay, calling back so soon?" Alpha Jackson said. It rubbed me the wrong way. Only my friends called me by my first name without my title. He was not one of my friends. But I swallowed it.

"Yes, I had a discussion with the top tier of the pack and we were all in agreement. The decision therefore didn't take long," I told him.

"I didn't expect anything else." I heard the smugness in his voice and it made me happy that I was about to give him a surprise.

"I'm happy you understand, Jackson. Your offer was more than generous, but my pack will not be joining yours. But we recognise the generosity in you giving us this offer and we would like to meet and discuss an alliance," I said. There was a long silence from the other side, if I hadn't heard him breathing I would have thought he left.

"You turn the offer down?" he asked.

"Yes. As generous as it is for you to offer it, we don't feel like it's in our best interest at this point."

"Have you forgotten that your pack is unranked?" Alpha Jackson asked.

"How can I forget a thing like that? No, I haven't forgotten. But we are satisfied we can protect ourselves if it is needed. If anyone deems it fit to test us, they will learn that even though we are unranked, we are strong," I said in a calm voice.

"That is good. Well, let's set up a meeting and talk alliance," Alpha Jackson said. He tried to sound relaxed and at peace with the outcome, but his anger bled through.



I was standing in front of the pack later that evening. I had called a pack meeting and the dining room in the pack house had been transformed into a meeting room. The tables had been made into a large square and everyone of age in the pack sat facing the middle. Me and my closest wolves sat at one side, all eyes on me.

"That is why we turned down their offer," I told the pack after I had explained things. There was an agreeing murmur amongst the gathered wolves.

"We don't want to join another pack," Jake said and others agreed.

"We left one pack because we felt oppressed. We won't give up our freedom for an unknown pack. If we wanted to trade our freedom for security, we would go back to our old one," Matilda told them. The pack agreed and I smiled at my aunt.

"We will meet with Alpha Jackson and two of his top wolves in two weeks time at a neutral location. We are looking into forming an alliance with them," I told the pack. I didn't tell them the meeting was more of an opportunity for us to assess their true nature. It wasn't that I didn't trust my pack, but I knew some things were best to keep close. "When we are gone, I want the rest of you to be on high alert. I don't think anything will happen. But I want us to be on the safe side," I said. Nodding heads agreed with me. We went on to talk about more mundane topics. Afterward the top tier retreated back to our meeting room.

"I will take two of you with me, so our groups are equal," I told them.

"Me and Sam should go with you. Amie and Medow can watch over the pack," Martin said. I was glad he had suggested it, so I didn't have to. My protectiveness towards Amie was strong, and I didn't know if I had it in me to have her with me in a hostile situation.

"That's a bad idea," Amie said and shattered my satisfied calm.

"Why?" I asked.



“Because Sam won’t be happy leaving Medow behind in a possibly dangerous situation. His focus won’t be on the meeting. Medow will be worried about Sam as he is going into a meeting with a threat against him. Besides that, Sam is the Gamma. If this is a ruse to get the strongest wolves away from the pack so they can attack behind our backs, it’s best if he is here. He knows the warriors and the defence plan better than anyone,” she explained. I hated that it made sense.

“It sounds logical,” Sam said as an echo of my own thoughts.

“I would be grateful to not be split up from Sam,” Medow agreed. I didn’t like the idea of bringing Amie with us to a potentially dangerous meeting. My wolf didn’t like it either. But she made too much fucking sense for me to object. I couldn’t find a single thing to use as a reason she should stay. Other than I didn’t like to put her in danger. And that would be too revealing. If we had been mates, even chosen ones, it would have been a good reason. Now it would just make things awkward.

“Fine. Martin and Amie, you will come with me. Sam and Medow, you will stay and guard the pack. We will keep in regular contact.”

“We have almost two weeks to plan and strategise,” Amie told us.

“Why does it sound like you are having fun?” Martin asked.

“Maybe not fun. I know how serious the situation is. But my dad always used to come back from meetings like this and tell me and my brother about how they had tried to trick each other and how they battled to get the upper hand in the negotiations. It always sounded like fun,” she told us. “I guess I’m looking forward to trying it out.” It reminded me how different our upbringings had been despite us both being the second child in a top ranking family. My father had

never been unkind to me. He had been a good father in most ways, and I thought of him fondly. He had just not seen the point of including me in his work. He knew my brother would take over after him, so from his point of view, it was just logical that he trained my brother. Amie’s family had done things differently, and I envied the openness they seemed to have shared. If I ever had pups of my own, I would do it like Amie’s father, I told myself.



## Chapter 18



### Amie

I was sitting in the back of Finlay's car. He and Martin sat up front. The tense energy rolled off of them in waves.

"Can we try to relax?" I asked. "I know this is a stressful meeting, but if we go in like this, we will add fuel to a fire." Finlay rolled his shoulders and tried to keep the car steady.

"You're right," Martin admitted and made a conscious effort to relax. "When we get there, I think it would make the most sense if me and the Alpha flanked you, Amie," he then said.

"Keep on dreaming. When have you ever seen an Alpha flank a member of their pack that isn't their Luna? Standard procedure is Alpha in the middle, you to the right and me to the left," I objected.

"I don't know, Amie," Finlay started to say.

"Okay. I know what this is and while I find it sweet that the two of you think you need to protect me, you don't. I'm here as a member of the top tier of the pack. We can't make it look like I'm weak. If nothing else, it will paint a target on my back. I can hold my own, thank you very much," I told them. They exchanged a look. "Don't make me slap you in the head."

"Fine. We do it as it should be done," Finlay agreed. I could see in the back view mirror he had the look on his face he usually had when he knew he was making the right decision, but he hated it.

"Fine," Martin said.

"Don't we all feel a lot better now? How long until we are there?" I asked. Both of them shook their heads.

"Twenty minutes," Finlay answered. I relaxed back. The tension was still there, but it had eased a bit. We had decided on a neutral meeting place roughly at the halfway point between the packs. As neither one of us wanted the other pack to know our exact location, it had been a best guess. We arrived at the meeting place. It was a rest stop in the middle of nowhere. A few picnic tables stood half buried in snow in the middle of a clearing next to the road. Finlay parked in the large parking area that was deserted this time of year. The cold did not affect werewolves as it did humans. We could sit in the snow and have the meeting. Finlay didn't have time to turn the car off before another car came from the opposite direction and parked on the other side of the parking lot. Everyone exited their car at the same time. Martin and I flanked Finlay as the two groups of wolves walked towards each other.

"Alpha Finlay, we finally meet."

“Alpha Jackson, a pleasure.” The two Alphas shook hands. I noticed Finlay was both taller and looked stronger than Alpha Jackson. Both me and my wolf took pride in that. The two men flanking Alpha Jackson looked like a cross between a bull and a bodybuilder. They took in me and Martin and I saw the smirk they gave us. They believed they could easily take us in a fight if it came to that. I smiled back. I believed that I could do some serious damage before I was taken down. I could even win a fight against one of them if I played my cards right. As the two Alphas walked over to a picnic table, we followed. The snow was cleared off and two tables were placed next to each other, mostly so that the Beta and Gamma of the other pack wouldn’t squeeze their Alpha into mush if they tried to all sit on one bench. We sat down and Alpha Jackson smiled at me.

“It’s an unusual choice to bring the Beta female to a meeting like this,” he said to Finlay. It was my upbringing that stopped me from scoffing and rolling my eyes. An Alpha should be treated with respect, even if he was an idiot.

“Amie is my advisor. She has her own seat among the top tier,” Finlay corrected him. “To my right is my Beta, Martin.” Alpha Jackson and his two men looked at me with surprise. That’s right, I have value, I thought to myself.

“To my right is my Beta, Peter, and to my left my Gamma, Stephen,” Alpha Jackson introduced them. As the formalities were over with, I took out the small bag I had with me and put sandwiches on the table and poured us all coffee from a thermos.

“Please, help yourself,” I told the other pack. All three of them stared at what I had offered. I could see them mindlinking each other.

‘I can’t believe that worked,’ Martin mindlinked me and Finlay.

‘Told you it would. If they refuse, they show they don’t trust us, which they don’t want to do. If they accept they have taken a gift from us without having something to repay it with. Then they are indebted to us,’ I linked back. Beta Peter took one of the mugs of coffee and sipped it.

“Thank you,” he said. I just nodded.

‘We win the first round,’ I linked to my two friends.

‘Remind me to not play any strategy based games with you, ever,’ Martin replied. The discussion between the Alphas moved slowly. It was clear there was no trust between them. I was suspicious of why Alpha Jackson was sitting opposite us when he clearly wasn’t interested in forming an alliance. I gathered the now empty mugs and empty sandwich wrappers and stuffed them back in the bag. As I did it, I looked at my phone. It was a message from Medow sent four minutes ago.

Medow: Everything is calm here. Hope you are doing well.

I linked Martin and Finlay to let them know. It made this whole thing even more confusing to me. If they weren’t interested in talking, and if they weren’t using this time to sneak attack us, then what were we doing here?

“I think we have come as far as we can today,” Finlay said after another round of meaningless discussion.

“I agree. I think we have made progress,” Alpha Jackson said. Both stood up and the rest of us followed. The Alphas stood to the side, shook hands and exchanged empty pleasantries. The Gamma walked up to me.

“If all the females in your pack look like you, we will need to give the merging of packs another go. Why don’t you and I take a little walk in the woods?” he suggested. Martin took a step in between us, facing the brute of a Gamma. “Protecting the little flower?” the man laughed. Martin chuckled.

“You think I’m protecting Amie? That’s cute. I’m not protecting her from you. I’m protecting you from her. My Alpha has gone to big trouble to get these talks going positively. I’m thinking that Amie maiming you by removing an appendage from you, probably one you really like, might toss a wrench in that. So, here I am, protecting you from her,” he told the gorilla-like man. I took pleasure in seeing the Gamma change his stance and close the gap between his legs. Finlay turned to look at us and I gave him a big smile. One of his eyebrows went up, as usual he saw through my attempt to look innocent. When we got back into the car and watched the others do the same, I still had the feeling I was missing something. As we left the parking area and headed for home, we all sat in silence for a while.

“Anyone else feel like they’re missing the big red blinking neon sign telling us what the fuck this meeting was?” Martin asked. Both Finlay and I laughed and agreed.

“He didn’t even try to broker an alliance,” Finlay said. “Not that I wanted one, but he made it obvious.”

“I was sure they intended to attack the pack behind our backs. But everything is still peaceful at home,” I said.

“That’s something to be grateful for,” Martin commented. Both Finlay and I agreed.

“It may be as easy as they wanted to assess how strong we are, and they decided we are too strong for them to mess with us,” Finlay suggested. The rest of the drive home was made mostly in silence. All three of us had things to think about.

When we got back to the pack, we could feel the tension in the air. As news about our safe return spread, the pack relaxed. We spent some time just walking around, letting the pack see us and talk to us. Then the top rank gathered in our meeting room to discuss the day. Sam and Medow had nothing to report. No stray wolves had been detected along the borders, no threats, nothing out of the ordinary. According to them, it had been a day like any other day. We ended up discussing the odd behaviour of Alpha Jackson and his Beta and Gamma. After hours, we reluctantly decided we had too little information to come to a conclusion. We decided to keep a close eye on the pack and increase the patrols of the borders. I could see how much it bothered Finlay to leave things open.



## Chapter 19



### Amie

Spring had finally come to the pack land and Finlay had decided to celebrate it with a BBQ at his house. Invited was the top tier, Matilda and Cadence family. Jake had trained the pups and adults in hiding and evading for almost two years. He had become close to both me and Sam and the pack had a new appreciation for him. He was an amazing strategist and was good at handling the pups, making the training into playtime. Finlay stood on his deck and manned the BBQ. I kept him company as the others were setting the table inside and cooked the side dishes.

"You look happy," he said.

"I am. I got an invitation from CeCe today. You remember her, right?"

"Sure. The woman who was there when we picked you up."

"Right. So, Jessie, the man who was there to see me off," I clarified for him. Finlay nodded but didn't look happy. "He proposed to CeCe, it was about time if you ask me, so they sent me a save the date for their wedding. June twenty fifth."

I told him. I didn't expect him to get all giddy like I had been when I read the invite. But I hadn't expected him to look like he had bitten into a lemon either. "What?"

"Nothing," he said. I gave him a look and he sighed.

"The Alpha meeting is the same week," he reminded me.

"Crap. I had totally forgotten. It's okay, I'll just tell them I can't make it."

"No, you should go. They are your friends and a wedding is a big deal," Finlay insisted.

"It is. But the pack comes first. You need someone to go with you and then someone needs to stay with the pack."

"I don't need someone to go with me. I'm a big Alpha, I can manage on my own. Beside, most Alphas take their Lunas as the plus one. I will be fine," he insisted. I hesitated. We didn't talk about it but his brother would be there and from what I could tell, the previous years hadn't been easy when the two met.

"Why do you both look like thunderclouds? It's spring, we are having a BBQ and we are supposed to be happy," Martin said as he came walking with a beer each for us.

"Thank you," I said, taking one.

"We were discussing that Amie has received a wedding invitation for her friends' wedding the same weekend that I'm to go to the Alpha meeting," Finlay said.

“Oh. So you told her you would go alone to the meeting and I would go with her, leaving Sam and Medow to watch over the pack and she didn’t like it?” Martin asked. I stared at him.

“What?” I said.

“I hadn’t got quite as far,” Finlay told him.

“Well, it’s the only reasonable solution.”

“Wait. Why do I need an escort? I’m going to a small town wedding with people I know, humans. Finlay is going into a week long meeting with every other pack. Some are openly hostile towards us. If anything he needs an escort,” I objected. Martin looked at Finlay and shrugged.

“He can look after himself,” he said.

“Look, Red. Just do as he says. The two of you can have some fun and we will feel safe knowing you are not alone. I will know to be on the lookout for trouble. But if trouble finds you, it will be unexpected,” Finlay said.

“Fine.” I caved. “As you are being kind enough to tag along, I will make sure to introduce you to all the single ladies in the town. They will have a field day with you,” I told Martin. He laughed and looked pleased. We had grown close and I saw Martin like an older brother. He always took the opportunity to tease me or make a joke that had me blushing. But at the same time he was protective of me and more than once when we had met other packs he teamed up with Finlay to make sure single wolves stayed away from me. I didn’t mind.

“Sounds like I’m the lucky one. I’ll let the others know,” Martin said and walked inside. Finlay and I stood in silence. It was a nice silence. I was looking out over his garden where Cadence was running around.

“You should get going with your garden, soon it will be too late,” I told him.

“My garden?” he asked, as if he had never heard of the concept.

“Yes. You know, milling and turning the soil, cutting down the perennials, planning what to plant in the garden patches. All the good stuff,” I explained.

“Oh, I don’t do that.”

“You don’t do that?”

“No.”

“Then what do you do with your garden?” I asked.

“Nothing really.” He must have seen the look on my face, because he continued. “When I built my house, I thought it was a good idea to have a garden. I imagined a mate, some pups, and then a garden was a nice touch. The pups could play out here, we could grow some vegetables. It felt right. It’s nice to be able to come out here in the summer, but I don’t have the time to tend to the garden and I barely eat at home, so the produce would go to waste,” he explained. Mates were a topic we usually stayed clear of. Not like it was a forbidden topic, but with my past and Finlay not having found his mate, it was a subject neither of us enjoyed.

“You shouldn’t let it go to waste. You have such an amazing garden,” I insisted.

"It was my aunt who designed it," he told me. It didn't surprise me.

"I'm guessing she isn't happy with the state of it," I told him with a knowing smile.

"No, I'm not," Matilda said as she joined us. "I have told him he needs to take care of it. I didn't plan it and oversee its creation to let it become overgrown," she added.

"Come now. It's not overgrown. I pay the Hudson kid each summer to mow the lawn and I usually cut down things that get too big," Finlay defended himself. Matilda rolled her eyes.

"I'm going to come over next weekend and sort out your garden. I will give you suggestions on what seeds to get and I will grow them for you. We can give the crop to the pack kitchen," I told him. Matilda smiled and nodded while her nephew just looked at me.

"Do you have time for that?" he asked. I shrugged.

"If you do it the right way, it doesn't have to take up that much time. I don't have a garden of my own and I kind of miss working in one," I said honestly. Growing up, it had been part of my brother's and mine tasks to help out in my mother's beloved garden. We had both protested, but secretly we both enjoyed it.

"Are you sure?" Finlay asked.

"Just accept her offer and say thank you," his aunt told him. "I would have done it myself if I was younger."

"Thank you," Finlay said to me. I laughed.

"It's okay. I will enjoy it."

"Isn't it time you start looking at getting a house of your own?" he asked. I scrunch my nose. I had the means to build a house. My salary from the pack was good and I didn't have things I spent my money on except for my share of the food budget in the pack house. But I had no desire to build my own house. I was happy in my apartment. I had been in the pack for almost a year and I had turned the room into my own.

"I think I will hold off on that," I said.

"Oh, honestly. The two of you. Clueless," Matilda told us. "I thought it would be nice with some spring air. But this is just frustrating," she sighed and walked away to talk to Cadence.

"What is she talking about?" I asked.

"I have no clue. It's probably something obvious to her but not to anyone else and she is annoyed that we haven't figured it out yet. She'll tell us when she is tired of us not seeing it," he said. "Are you sure you are okay with looking after the garden? I know you have a lot on your plate."

"I am. It will be relaxing, and I have missed gardening."

"Then just give me a list of what I need to get and I will make sure you have it. I trust you know what is best. The only thing I will ask is that you grow sugar pees. I love picking and eating them," he told me.



"I think we can make that happen. I'll stop by on Saturday and when I'm done for the day, you will have your list."

## Chapter 20



### Amie

Martin refused to ride in Beula to the wedding. He told me no self respecting wolf would ever be seen in a car like that, and we would most likely end up stranded by the side of the road if we did. I thought he was being judgmental. Beula had done me good. She had always been reliable. But since he refused, we were sitting in his car with him behind the wheel. It had been over two years since I left the little town to join the pack. I had kept in touch with CeCe but it still felt strange returning. The part of my life where I had lived as a human felt like a dream.

“Excited to go back and see your friends?” Martin asked.

“I am. It will be nice to see everyone, and I’m happy for CeCe and Jessie. This has been a long time coming,” I told him.

“So, how do you want to introduce me? As your boyfriend?” he asked with a grin. I laughed.

“Don’t be gross,” I said. He laughed as well.

“Come on, I thought it was a big deal to have a date for events like these when you are human,” he insisted.

“I guess it is. I never understood that part of their culture. Maybe because I’m werewolf and we don’t tend to place as much importance on dating. Or maybe it’s because of the whole rejection thing. And since I’m dragging you to this thing, I don’t want to block you from having some fun. The ladies will go crazy for you, trust me. You have a high chance of scoring at this thing. But it won’t be with me,” I told him and giggled.

“Of course not with you, who is being gross now? I don’t need to score, I do good on that department when I want to. Are you planning to score?” he asked.

“You know me. I’m staying away from anything romantic.”

“Yeah, I know. And I get why in the pack. All single wolves have a potential mate out there, it’s a one-sided risk in your case. Totally get it. But these are humans, there is no such risk here.”

“Maybe not. I’m not interested in a one-night thing. I know these men, they are not someone I would consider for a relationship. I guess it would make sense for me to have a relationship with a human. But I don’t like the idea. There is a huge gap between how we live and how we see the world,” I said. And then there was this thing between Finlay and me. I didn’t say it, but I knew that as long as I had unresolved feelings for our Alpha, no one else would feel right.

“You should know since you lived among them for years. Then I don’t see why you don’t just tell people I’m your boyfriend.”

“Because we are going to a wedding. One of the most romantic social events in the human world. If I show up with my boyfriend they will expect us to act all lovey dovey, kissing and cuddling and slow dancing and stuff,” I explained and looked at him. He made a face and I laughed. I loved Martin and I knew he loved me, but we were more like brother and sister and anything else felt wrong. Imagining kissing Martin felt the same as imagining kissing Elder. “Thought so.”

“Fine, I get it. But just so we are clear, I will make sure other men stay away from you.” I laughed and shook my head.

“And why is that? You just asked me if I planned to get laid.”

“That was to scope your intentions. Now I know I don’t have to talk sense into you and I can just do my thing,” he said, and sounded pleased.

“What is up with you?” I asked. He glanced over at me and sighed.

“Let’s talk about the elephant in the car.”

“Do we have one of those?” I asked.

“We do. You know I love you like a sister.”

“I do.”

“And Finlay is my best friend.” Oh shit, I thought. “I’m not blind, I can see whatever it is between the two of you. It’s frustrating to watch but it’s up to you to deal with. I’m just making sure that since he can’t be here, I will make sure I keep you safe.” My heart was pounding in my chest. I thought I had been hiding my feelings.

“Does everyone know?” I asked.

“No. Matilda does, because she sees everything. Maybe Medow does as well, but she hides it well if she does. Sam has no clue. The rest of the pack. I don’t think they see what I see. But everyone knows the two of you are close. Why do you act as if it’s a problem if the others know?”

“I don’t know. It’s between Finlay and me and we don’t even talk about it. It’s just kind of just is.”

“And why is that?”

“Because if we talk about it we need to make a decision on how to move forward and I’m too big of a coward for that,” I said. He laughed, but when he noticed me not laughing, he glanced at me.

“You are serious?”

“I am.”

“But what is there to be scared of? And I have never seen you scared, why are you running away from this of all things?”

“Because. Because there are two outcomes. Either we decide to start something or we decide to leave it and pretend it doesn’t exist.”

“Right.”

“What if we give it a try and he finds his mate?” I asked.

“Yeah, I see that it’s a shitty option. But he is almost twenty-five and he hasn’t found her despite having been to several packs the last few years in his role as Alpha. The risk is low that he will find her. She could be dead or mated and then he never will,” Martin told me.

“But if he does?”

“I have seen how he looks at you, Amie. I don’t think that will change. My guess is he would choose you.”

“And then I will be the reason why someone gets rejected. I know how that feels, I wouldn’t wish it on my worst enemy. How could I do that to someone?”

“I see your point. But if the two of you mate his link to his true mate will be cut. Then there would be no rejection,” he pointed out.

“Just someone that will forever be looking for their mate that I stole. And could I do that to Finlay? His true mate is his perfect match. This whole thing is such a fucking mess. I hate it,” I sighed and shook my head.

“I’m sorry, Amie. I didn’t want to make you upset. I just see how the two of you act and to me it’s obvious the two of you belong together. I didn’t consider all the

things around it. I get why you don’t talk about it.”

“It’s okay. I just don’t want things between me and Finlay to become strange or awkward. He is too important to me. So for now, we will continue this, whatever it is.”

“I get it. If you need to vent, you can always talk to me. I will keep your secrets safe,” he promised. I smiled.

“You are amazing and I’m thankful you’re in my life. And thank you for coming with me to this wedding. I won’t feel lonely when you are here,” I told him.

“Hey, you are my little sister in all but blood. Of course I came with you. Just know that our talk hasn’t changed my mind. I will still make sure the men keep away from you,” he told me. I laughed.

“I don’t mind.”

We arrived in the town in the afternoon and I guided Martin to the diner. I had barely got out of the car when I found myself in a hug. CeCe squealed as she hugged me. I laughed and hugged her back.

“You look amazing!” she told me.

“Look who’s talking. You are radiant,” I said to her. She giggled.

“I am annoyingly happy,” she confessed, making me laugh.

“As you should be. Come and meet my friend,” I said and pulled her over to where Martin stood with an amused smile. “CeCe this is Martin, Martin this is CeCe, the bride to be,” I introduced them.

“Hello, and congratulations,” he said.

“Thank you and welcome to the metropolitan we call home.” CeCe leaned into me. “That’s not the man you left with,” she whispered. Martin could hear her with his improved hearing, and he had to fight not to laugh.

“I know,” I whispered back.

“Where is the other one? Did you dump him?” she continued our whispered conversation.

“I told you, me and Finlay are just friends. He had to go on a business trip,” I explained.

“And you just had a spare hunk lying around? What is this place you have moved to and can I come as well?” she asked. Martin had to pretend to look for something in the back of his car. But my hearing and the slight shaking of his shoulders told me he was laughing.

“CeCe!” I pretended to be shocked. “You are getting married tomorrow.”

“I know. But I mean,” she said, doing a small gesture behind Martin’s back, indicating his ass. I laughed.

“I’m happy you haven’t changed,” I told her. She sighed and shook her head.

“I have strict orders to escort you to the diner and then we will go to the coffeeshop. Mrs Andersen has turned the apartment over her shop into an Air BnB. Me and Jessie rented it for you.”

“CeCe! You didn’t have to. We could have stayed in the motel,” I said.

“Ew, nasty. You are our only out of town guests. It’s only right that we put you up. But, there is only one bed,” CeCe said.

“That won’t be a problem, we will manage,” Martin told her as he reached for my overnight bag as well as his own. CeCe poked her elbow into my side.

“Just friends, huh?” she remarked. I just rolled my eyes as we walked to the diner. It was nice to see everyone again. Mrs Jones gave me a tight hug and ushered Martin and me to a table and insisted on feeding us before we headed to her sister’s. CeCe and Jessie joined us. They both looked relaxed for a couple who had a wedding the next day. Very little had changed in town and the diner was still a meeting hub, the locals had heard about my return and many came by to say ‘hi’ and talk a little. Martin kept his word and made sure men kept a distance from me. CeCe and Mrs Jones gave me amused looks and I figured they didn’t buy my ‘just friends’ explanation. After eating and talking for a couple of hours, CeCe and Jessie took us over to the coffeeshop and Mrs Andersen gave me a tight hug before she shooed the bride and groom away.

“Honestly, the two of them are treating this as just another party. In my days, the day you married your husband was the most important day of your life,” she huffed as she showed us the apartment. At least the apartment had changed since I saw it last. It was now decorated in an idyllic countryside chick. “I hope